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ACOMPARATIVE STUDY ON OTT PLATFORMS AND THEIR IMPACT ON INDIA'S FILM INDUSTRY

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ABSTRACT:

With the arrival of Over-The-Top (OTT) services into India, the film industry in India has been transformed rapidly since these services have changed how the people of India consume film and entertainment (i.e., online platforms like Netflix, Amazon Prime Video, Disney+ Hot Star, ZEE5), as well as influenced production, distribution, and revenue models in the film industry across India, due in large part to the increasing prevalence of smart devices, affordable Internet access, and greater availability of digital content to the public. This study will provide a comparative overview of the three largest OTT platforms (Netflix, Amazon Prime Video, and Disney+ Hot Star) that are operating in India's film industry, with an emphasis on examining each platform's content strategies, subscription models, user engagement, and market positions. "This study will also assess how these platforms offer new and/or innovative distribution methods and opportunities for filmmakers — especially independent filmmaker (i.e., creators of regional content) — as an alternative to traditional theatrical releases. "In addition, the study focuses on the paradigm shift of 'direct-to-digital' film releases that were undertaken—especially since the global COVID-19 pandemic hit in 2020—which is another trend that is picking up speed". At the same time, the emergence of OTT services has introduced a range of issues for traditional movie theaters and traditional distribution channels. "The studies will examine the economic and creative impact of shifting the approach to increase the user-specific, on-demand viewing experience of films (i.e., more available on demand)". After examining the secondary sources (reviews, industry reports etc) and conducting a comparative analysis, the article brings out into the consciousness of the reader that the introduction of OTTs has resulted in a paradigm shift in the Indian film industry. OTTs have enabled audience to get more exposure and diversified them across the globe, but it is also forcing additional competition and underlying transformation in the film industry itself". The key words used in this article are OTTs, Indian Film Industry, Digital streaming, Comparative Studies, Film Distribution, Audience Behavior and Media transformation.

Keywords: *OTT Platforms; Indian Film Industry; Digital Streaming; Film Distribution; Audience Behavior; Direct-to-Digital Release; Media Transformation.*

Introduction

Indian films are among the most extensive around the globe in terms of production and audience consumption, and within the digital landscape and use of technology, have undergone a pivotal transformation. “Historically, film revenue was generated via theatrical distribution and through selling satellite TV rights, and accessing physical distribution channels to customers. With the onslaught of OTT (Over-The-Top) streaming service offerings to consumers, such a traditional paradigm has been upended because they provide viewers with the ability to watch directly from their point of origin (the internet)”.

Services provided by OTT let watchers enjoy video signals without having to tune into one via a cable network (such as TV). “Thanks to the increase in smartphones that are affordable for consumers, the development and increasing availability of high-speed Internet service (facilitated, in part, by the new low-cost data plan options), and the high rate of digital literacy, OTT consumption has grown across Territory”.

As result, “digital streaming is becoming a more acceptable way of entertainment now than ever before for people in cities and in rural regions.

Hence, the goal of this study is to compare and contrast the impact of the movie streaming service of Sony Liv, Amazon Prime Video and the Disney Plus Hotstar on the film industry of India”.

Going to a movie theatre has turned into a whole new subject During the era the Covid-19 pandemic shut down movie theatres nationwide, “the transformation of the sector had grown more prominent. Over this period of time, OTT (over-the-top) gradually emerged as the leading distribution avenue for films and web series to consumers. Even premiere OTT platforms like Sony LIV, Amazon Prime Video and Disney+ Hotstar enhanced their market presence with the launch of original shows and movies, regional releases and direct-to-digital release of feature films. OTT platforms have enabled filmmakers to continue making movies and transformed consumer viewing habits”.

“In contrast, OTT providers have a subscription based (SVOD), advertisement based (AVOD) or hybrid revenue model, in which they can offer the consumers low cost and flexible viewing options. OTT platforms utilize personalized recommendations and offer multilingual possibilities and on-demand content provision to enhance the user experience. Besides, OTT platforms have given independent filmmakers and regional filmmakers national and international exposure that they'll find unavailable with any theatres in between”.

Growth in the OTT space has also sparked scrutiny into the future of the movie-going and box office experience, as well as potential content regulation and competition in the industry. “Although large budget movies continue to rely on theatrical releases to achieve maximum revenue, medium and smaller budget movies have turned to OTT due to lower risks and assurances of returns.

By studying OTT's business models such as pricing, penetration and influence in the production, distribution and viewing mechanisms of movies in India, researchers are able to develop an understanding of how OTT relate in a complementary way but also how it has started to supplant the traditional movie business model”.

Literature Review

“As numerous scholars across various academic fields conduct research into the booming growth of Over-The-Top (OTT) streaming media such as Netflix, Amazon Prime Video, Disney+ Hotstar, and ZEE5 (Lotz, 2017; Tryon, 2013), researchers are focusing on how these types of services have changed global entertainment consumption behaviors. The infrastructure for services offered to viewers by OTT media allows viewers to obtain these types of media products, irrespective of time or place, that challenges the existing distribution systems of films and television using brick and mortar movie theaters or television channels”.

The proliferation of OTT in India can be blamed solely on the expansion of affordable internet connectivity (Athique, 2019) given the rise of the smartphone, cheap internet service and the increase in digital literacy in India. “The high usage of digital media products, irrespective of geographic area (urban-rural), has been highly supportive of the rapid strides being made by OTT video streaming in India, and this is primarily owing to the low-cost internet connectivity, as per research. (EY & FICCI Report, 2021) This implies that India's OTT video streaming business is growing one of the fastest developing video streaming businesses in the world”.

The change in the model of distribution of films in India with the advent of OTTs has also been studied. “Satellite rights and box office receipts abroad have been a important source of revenue for small film distributors, as has been with the theatrical box office (Ganti, 2012). Other studies do note, however, that OTT has added new means of generating revenue to the film distribution business model—such as the direct to digital release and the sale of digital rights (Lobato, 2019)). The fundamentals of this shift to OTT were clearly visible during the pandemic when cinema halls and multiplexes have been closed, and various films opted for an online premiere (see EY & FICCI Report, 2022)”. The shift to OTT has brought a radical change in how both audiences are accessing and consuming films and has also enabled filmmakers to continue generating revenues in an uncertain scenario.

Content diversity has been another important aspect, very frequently addressed by prior studies. “The existence of OTT has also been cited for its ability to create space for diversity in cinema, opening up opportunities to experiment with storytelling, genre and regional screenings, and thus providing more opportunities for experimentation in cinema (Lobato, 2019). Instead of star power and mass appeal being the key for success, OTT offers opportunities for independent film makers and regional content makers to create and distribute their films. People are becoming more drawn to kinds of narratives, television series and films that are not really that common to have success in traditional cinemas (Tryon, 2015)”.

These researchers have done comparative analysis of the business models of major OTT platforms, studying some of their content libraries, user interfaces and subscription pricing (Lotz, 2017). “The comparative analysis reveals that global platforms stream movies on streaming platforms like Netflix and Amazon Prime Video that are specifically meant for international movies while Indian streaming platforms like ZEE5 and Disney+ Hotstar emphasize to original movies in regional languages that cater to viewers' tastes. This has been recognised as an important tactic to date in the swift growth of the Indian OTT landscape (KPMG Media and Entertainment Report 2022)”.

There are other challenges that have been identified in the literature that stem from the growth rate of the OTT platforms. “According to many researchers, competition has also played a role in the content oversaturation due to the high speed of growth of OTT platforms (Lobato, 2019). Others are talking about regulatory matters, censorship problems and the impact of releasing digital content on theatre box office revenue (Athique, 2019). Besides the debate over whether or not OTT will be a ‘complementary service' to the traditional cinema hall and whether or not it will completely take over traditional cinema, there's also some discussion on whether or not OTT companies are indeed offering a complementary service to the traditional cinema”.

In general, research shows that the OTT platforms have had a massive amount of influence over the Indian movie industry. In particular, OTT platforms have caused changes in production and distribution methods as well as changing the revenue models and the behavior of moviegoers in India. However, there still is a need for a focused analysis comparing both the OTT platforms and their more wide-ranging impacts on the ecosystem of Indian cinema. In an effort to fill this void, the current study will provide a comparative analysis of several major OTT platforms and would assess their contributions to the transformation of the Indian movie industry.

Objectives of the Study

- Compare and contrast Netflix versus Amazon Prime in India
- Analyze both companies' strategies around content acquisition and subscriber model
- Learn what the effect of OTT platforms has been on Indian cinema
- Investigate the ways audiences are changing
- Research the overall development of the OTT industry within India

Research Methodology

This study will use a descriptive and comparative research design to examine how over-the-top (OTT) platforms have affected the Indian film industry. The study will focus specifically on two OTT platforms: Netflix and Amazon Prime Video.

1.Research Approach

This research will use a descriptive approach to study the development, characteristics, and impact of OTT platforms on the Indian Film Industry. Comparative analysis will also be used among the various OTT services based on different factors such as the content offered by each service, price points, and user engagement.

2. Data Collection Method(s)

This study relies solely on secondary data sources. Data used for this study comes from:

- Industry reports (KPMG, EY, FICCI, etc.)
- Research papers and/or journals
- Official websites of each OTT service
- Articles and online publications from sources of news or media

3. Data Collection Methodology

The data used for this research was collected through document review and online data (information on OTT Platforms and their growth and impact on the film industry). All pertinent data has been sorted and methodically categorized.

4. Analysis Tool/Techniques

The analysis tools and techniques used in this study are qualitative (through comparative analysis) and quantitative. This study utilizes the following analysis tools/techniques:

- Comparative analysis of Netflix and Amazon Prime Video
- Analyzing the secondary data
- Tabulating quantitative data in charts (bar graphs, pie charts, line charts) to facilitate comprehension.

5. Scope of Study

- The scope of this study is defined as follows:
- Major OTT platforms in India (primarily Netflix and Amazon Prime Video)
- Imposition on the production, distribution and consumption of Film
- Changes in consumer behaviour within the Indian market.6. Limitations of the Study
- Only secondary data was used for this study
- The analysis is limited to very few platforms
- The results may differ significantly from future results because of the fluidity of the OTT industry
- No primary survey or field research has been performed

Background of OTT Platform

OTT (Over the Top) services have fundamentally changed the global entertainment business. “In India two biggest platforms affecting the way digital media will be consumed are Netflix and Amazon Prime Video. Both platforms ventured into India in 2016 and both have been expanding since then, with movies, series, documentaries and original shows”.

The company was founded in 1997 by Reed Hastings and Marc Randolph as a company that lets people rent DVDs, and enters online streaming in 2007. “Now it works in more than 190 countries and is known from its emphasis on original content and global stories. Netflix is also a producer of its own shows or programmes,

which have been named as “Netflix Originals”, and has collaborated with film makers across the globe, even with Indian film makers. Some Netflix Indian originals that contribute to the brand identity are "Sacred Games", "Delhi Crime", "Lust Stories" and "Jamtara". Moreover, Netflix is a subscription-based video on demand service (SVOD), offering different rates and mobile-only packages to entice more people to make use of their smartphone. Plus, its sophisticated recommendation functions and tailored users’ interfaces assist keep site visitors returning repeatedly, showing that it's a high-quality worldwide entertainment provider”.

Similarly, Amazon Prime Video is Amazon's and was born in 2006, with expansion overseas and eventually areas like India in 2016. “Amazon's video-service has a large list of choices available; it includes original shows, worldwide shows as well as Bollywood movies and regional movies. In fact, a number of Indian productions have proven to be immensely popular among the streaming service subscribers from India such as the Mirzapur, Made in Heaven, The Family Man, Paatal Lok, etc. Amazon Prime Video has a bundle or combined subscription model where customers pay for their subscription as part of their Amazon Prime membership which provides them with additional benefits that include free shipping, streaming music and exclusive shopping deals. Amazon Prime has developed relationships with indian producers and its operations across the region are growing on ways in which it can provide content to its viewers. Operating out of Amazon's video tech, X-Ray enables the fast viewing of the characters in an episode and what they're doing before, during and after that screen time”.

Both these streaming services have different approaches to building engagement among their viewers in India. “Netflix has chosen to focus on producing original content at the highest level of quality possible while telling stories that are available globally, while Amazon Prime Video has chosen to produce content that will meet the needs of Indian residents with a focus on affordability and regional content; additionally, they integrate their video's content with their current Amazon Prime membership, providing a high-value proposition to potential subscribers. Together, Netflix and Amazon Prime Video have positively impacted the growth of OTT services and transformed the way digital entertainment is consumed in India”.

Comparative Analysis of Netflix and Amazon Prime Video in India

India has seen a large influx of OTT services, with the competition between the various providers becoming increasingly intense. At the top of this competition are Netflix and Amazon Prime Video; both of whom have established operations in India since 2016. Both platforms have had a profound impact on the digital entertainment landscape and upon each other. However, there are notable differences in how Netflix and Amazon have approached their respective strategies, pricing, and content.

1. Content Strategy

The two companies scheme their contents differ in a huge way.

For instance, with Netflix, they produce only the best of the best original content as well as they offer Originals from around the world. “The company puts in a lot more to produce their own movies and shows and they can all in some capacity, look good to an American audience. Some of Netflix's Originals that have been well-made are the Indian Originals (Sacred Games, Delhi Crime and Jamtara)”.

Substantial different from Netflix, Amazon's Prime Video release many more types of content and produce a LOT more Original (Local) content. “The company ties up with the Bollywood Production houses and smaller companies (Regional) of India for acquiring digital rights for movies and hereby creates fresh Local Originals. Some of the shows that garnered a big following among Indian viewers on Amazon's Prime Video platform are Mirzapur, The Family Man, Paatal Lok, and more.

To sum up, despite the fact that they are proceeding in different ways, both companies are investing in Original Programming. Netflix's mantra is to producing a big catalogue of Global Originals, whereas for Amazon Prime Video, it is more about the Regional and Mainstream productions that are made in India”.

.2. Subscription Model

The core difference really comes down to how each platform handles its subscription model.

Take Netflix, “for instance. It operates strictly as a subscription-based video-on-demand (SVOD) service. There are no add-ons or extra perks; you are purely paying a monthly fee to watch their library. That cost scales depending on the video quality you want and how many screens you need to stream on at the same time”.

Amazon Prime Video, “on the other hand, takes a completely different approach by bundling its streaming service into the broader Amazon Prime membership. When you subscribe, you are not just getting movies and TV shows you also get free shipping on Amazon purchases, access to music streaming, and exclusive shopping deals”.

Because of this bundled approach, consumers especially in a price-sensitive market like India often perceive Prime Video as the much cheaper, high-value option. “You feel like you're getting an entire ecosystem of benefits for a single price, rather than just paying for another streaming app”.

3. User Engagement and Features

Though both platforms utilize technology to improve consumers' overall experience, there are many differences in terms of features provided by each platform.

Netflix has an advanced recommendation engine that provides users with custom tailored content based on the user's viewing habits, in addition to multiple profiles, creating a watch list or ability to download shows and movies for offline use.

Amazon Prime Video also has similar features to Netflix, except that it has a unique feature called X-Ray which displays information about various actors, actresses, characters and scenes while you watch the show or movie.

Whereas Amazon Prime Video gets more interactive thanks to the additional interactive features, Netflix goes by Personalization by means of Ai

4. Market Positioning

Both of these are offering marketing strategies in different ways in India.

Netflix wants to become a high-quality original production and superior streaming powered international entertainment service. Netflix has become a brand synonymous with foreign content and movies.

In contrast, Amazon Prime Video is a value type platform that gives entertainment along with all benefits/privileges that the Amazon Ecosystem offers. The company has built itself to offering the cheapest and most widely varied local product/service to their customers.

5. Regional Content and Localization

The shift toward localization in India's OTT space is impossible to ignore, and you can see it clearly in how Amazon Prime Video and Netflix have played their cards.

"Instead of sticking to a one-size-fits-all approach, Prime Video went all-in on regional markets early on. They poured serious investment into Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, and Kannada content. Because they focused on meeting viewers where they were—speaking their language and telling local stories—they managed to build a massive, widespread footprint across the country".

Netflix, "on the other hand, took a different route at the start. While they were definitely looking to expand in India, their early strategy leaned heavily toward urban audiences and glossy, English-language or globally-appealing storytelling. Because they focused on that specific niche initially, it left the door wide open for Prime Video to capture a much broader, more geographically diverse audience across India".

6. Contribution to the Indian Film Industry

"Both of them have done the following for the Indian film industry, ushering in a golden era in the process":

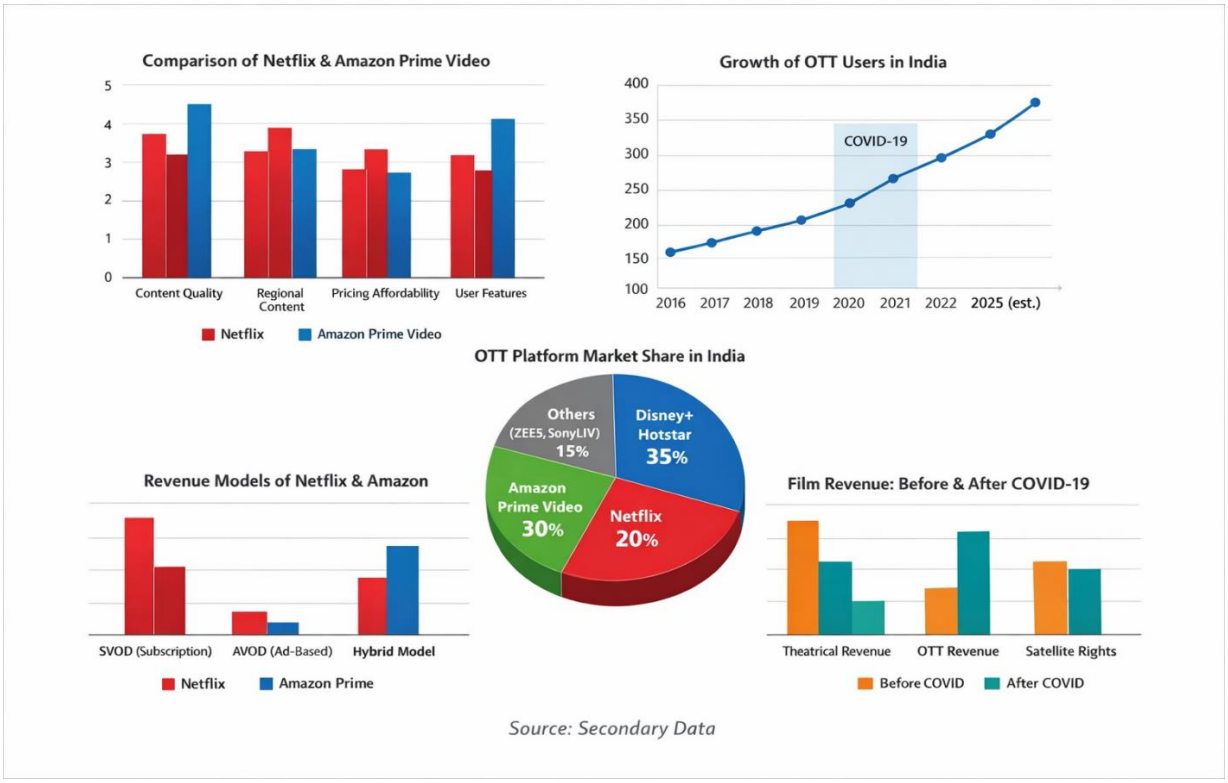
- Began to generate revenue from the sale of digital rights
- Encouraged Media Content Buyers to purchase web series and original movies
- Gained global visibility for Indian material, product and service images
- Adopted changes in viewing habits due to streaming video on the Web

But their approaches are not the same "Netflix takes stool design, focuses on good content; Amazon relies on collaboration with Indians, different types of market"

7. Other OTT platforms compete with Telesco Other OTT services are competing with Telesco.

Both have run into stiff competition with the rest of India's competitive streaming scene, as many other platforms have been making their mark, such as ZEE5 and Disney+ Hotstar. This increasing amount of competition among different platforms has resulted in additional investment into the production of digital

content within entire OTT space.



Findings of the Study

1. "OTT services have brought a revolution in the way people used to watch films in India by diverting their attention from traditional cinema theaters to video on demand (VOD) over the internet".

2. "The rise of OTT services has been mainly brought about by growing number of smartphone owners, availability of low-cost internet services and improved digital accessibility in urban and rural areas".

3. COVID-19 pandemic played a major role in pushing the users to use OTT services, as they were not able to go to movie theaters, they had no other option but to use digital entertainment.

4." Netflix's premium scheme is hinged on good quality original shows that have a global audience while Amazon Prime Video's pricing is hinged on the ability to offer consumers a number of shows at an appealing price point, in addition to a mix of local/regional programming, making it easier for viewers outside major urban areas to find something of interest to watch".

5.For a streaming service to keep people hooked, regional content isn't just a nice-to-have feature—it's the whole game. This focus on local programming is exactly what has given Amazon Prime Video such a massive competitive edge in the Indian market.

6. "OTT platforms have completely rewritten the rules for indie filmmakers. They no longer have to fight for limited, expensive theater screens; streaming has opened up a massive alternative distribution highway. Because of this, the entire financial blueprint of Indian filmmaking is shifting. Revenue is steadily moving away from traditional box-office sales and satellite TV rights and flowing directly into digital pockets".

7. Audience habits have fundamentally changed. Viewers aren't willing to build their schedules around a TV broadcast or a theater showtime anymore. They expect content on-demand, fitting seamlessly into their actual lives and routines.

8. "While OTT platforms are absolutely turning up the heat on the competition for our attention, they aren't killing off traditional movie theaters just yet. For now, streaming and big-screen cinema are acting more like partners that complement each other, rather than rivals trying to completely replace one another".

Conclusion

Ultimately, "it's clear that OTT platforms have completely reshaped the landscape of the Indian film industry. Driven by the explosive growth of smartphones, cheap data, and a highly tech-savvy public, streaming services have fundamentally changed how people watch and engage with stories".

When you look at the giants of the space, "Netflix and Amazon Prime Video offer a textbook study in contrasting strategies. Netflix chose to play the premium card, betting on high-end original productions and global storytelling. Prime Video took the opposite route, anchoring itself in affordability, a massive volume of regional content, and the built-in value of the Amazon Prime ecosystem. By executing these distinct game plans, both platforms have successfully captured different slices of the massive Indian market, fueling their own steady growth".

"This shift goes far deeper than just user habits; it has transformed the entire pipeline of how movies are made, sold, and funded. The pandemic supercharged this evolution, turning direct-to-digital releases from a temporary workaround into a permanent, viable option to traditional theater windows. This has been a massive

win for independent filmmakers and regional creators, who used to struggle for distribution but can now instantly find a massive, built-in audience on streaming platforms".

"That said, the rise of streaming hasn't spelled the end for movie theatres. Instead, we're seeing a new ecosystem where the two coexist and complement one another. While massive blockbusters still rely on the spectacle and revenue of a traditional theatrical release, small and medium-budget films have found a safer, more profitable home on OTT platforms, where they are guaranteed an audience without the financial risk of a theatre run".

"Looking ahead, streaming platforms will undoubtedly remain a driving force in the future of Indian cinema. Their ultimate success will come down to how well they continue to innovate and adapt to changing tastes. As the dust settles, the way traditional cinema and digital platforms learn to collaborate and share the spotlight will ultimately define the next great chapter of India's entertainment industry".

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